

The role of the Scientific Advisory Group (SAG)

The SAG is a part-time panel of independent experts appointed by the Director of Biosecurity under the [Biosecurity Regulation 2016](#) for the purpose of reviewing and commenting on any aspect of a [Biosecurity Import Risk Analysis \(BIRA\)](#). We can also utilise members of the SAG in their capacity as independent experts through separate engagements to review other risk analyses we undertake.

The SAG consists of three standing members, appointed for a four-year term, commencing 30 March 2026 through to 29 March 2030. The SAG members are:

Chair — Emeritus Professor Simon Maddocks

Economist — Dr Terence Farrell

Risk Analysis Specialist — Dr Marion Healy

We may also appoint additional members if required.

The Director of Biosecurity may ask the SAG to consider, for example, whether:

- technical submissions received from stakeholders in response to the draft BIRA report have been properly considered
- all relevant matters relating to the likely economic consequences of a disease or pest incursion have been properly considered
- the conclusions of the draft and provisional BIRA report are logical and scientifically reasonable, based on the material presented and any other issues have arisen during the BIRA process.

The SAG provides its findings to the Director of Biosecurity for consideration when preparing the preliminary BIRA report.

Review of the SAG

The department reviewed the role of the SAG in response to the 2025 Inspector General of Biosecurity's review report no [2024-25/01](#).

Role review key findings

- Under the [Biosecurity Regulation 2016](#), the SAG can only examine aspects of a BIRA when directed by the Director of Biosecurity; it has no authority to advise on matters outside BIRAs. Additional SAG members can be appointed as needed, and the Director of Biosecurity can seek further expert advice to support a BIRA at any time.
- Extending SAG membership terms beyond the typical 30-month BIRA duration would support consistency, especially if multiple BIRAs occur or timelines are extended.
- While the SAG cannot formally advise on non-BIRA issues, the department can still commission individual SAG members for their expert input through separate contracts.

- The department already draws on a broad pool of independent experts including individual SAG members, scientists, and stakeholders when undertaking non-BIRA assessments, noting that consultation and publication requirements differ from BIRA processes.

Role review outcomes

- The SAG's role remains fit for purpose and no regulatory changes are required.
- SAG member terms have been extended to up to four years to improve continuity.
- SAG member recruitment occurs through a public approach to market, merit-based assessment of candidates, and recommended appointments are approved by the Director of Biosecurity.
- The SAG's role, composition and governance will be reviewed periodically and as required, including following completion of a BIRA where appropriate.
- The SAG's Term of Reference was updated to reflect the review.

The department also conducted a review of the BIRA Guidelines to ensure the guidelines are consistent with the [Biosecurity Regulation 2016](#) and adopt a principles-based approach to conducting a BIRA. The outcomes of the review and the updated BIRA Guidelines can be accessed here: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/risk-analysis/undertaking-import-risk-analysis/guidelines>

Contact

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Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/risk-analysis/conducting-import-risk-analysis/scientific-advisory-group>